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JAILER TAKES CHARGE: A CELEBRATION OF RAJINI P4





Step back in time

Vintage kolu dolls are attracting collectors as prices go up every year. How much are your heirlooms worth?

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For families that possess vintage kolu dolls, heirlooms are a matter of pride.

"We have dolls that are more than 100 years old, handmade from wood," says 70-year-old TK Balakrishnan who, along with his wife, Usha, creates an annual display. "Known as Mysore bommai or Gowri bommai, these dolls were collected by my grandmother, Sundari Thirumurti, who was an art connoisseur," says Balakrishnan.

The wooden Gowri bommai in their collection stands out not only for their age but also for their ingenious construction. Usha explains that the dolls can be dismantled, with the torso, head, hands, palms, thighs and legs separated, and reassembled. This allows them to be dressed as different gods.

"We tried recreating them, but it was impossible to replicate the originals because of its craftsmanship. This year, we have used them to depict episodes from Krishna's life, including Govardhana Giri, Raasa Leela and Thulabaram," says Usha.

Their collection also includes Lakshmi and Saraswathi dolls in immaculate condition, both believed to be more than 100 years old, proving that their expansive collection is not just ancient but certainly valuable.

It hence becomes evident that for families who have inherited these dolls, preserving them is as important as displaying them. Their faded colours, worn surfaces, repaired limbs and carefully maintained costumes bear witness to years of use and affection.

Abhinav Vinayakh Shankarnarayanan, co-founder of Cherish Vintage Finds, states that the market value of these heirlooms has shot up over the last two years. Today, the vintage dolls he deals in are priced up to ₹40,000 as it has become more challenging to find heirloom dolls in a good condition with the original paintwork now. Meanwhile people are also beginning to value the high quality craftsmanship of the past.

"Those who sell their family collections are not doing so to make money. They simply want to ensure that these precious treasures are preserved in someone else's home. The buyers of these vintage dolls are often Indians settled abroad or South Indians living in other parts of the country," says Abhinav.

Art curator Ashvin E Rajagopalan, founder of Ashvita's Art Gallery, says he has been collecting Chennai-based cultural objects, including kolu dolls, and has archived more than 1,000 dolls so far. "Currently, we are only curating and archiving these handcrafted kolu dolls after restoring them at the conservation lab in our gallery. Three-dimensional kolu dolls inspired by Ravi Varma paintings are in great demand," says Ashvin.

He explains that when a kolu doll is sourced, he assesses it by examining the quality of the paint, the workmanship, the detailing and the size. Ashvin says that an art object is considered an antique if it is more than 100 years old, while an object that is more than 50 years old is classified as vintage. The age drives up the value, he adds.

Documenting the past

Kolu dolls bring together painting, printmaking and craft.



The oleographs of Raja Ravi Varma helped popularise particular visual representations of deities providing inspiration for generations of doll makers.

This relationship between art and craft can be seen in the vintage dolls preserved at DakshinaChitra, the heritage museum in Chennai. The museum has an extensive collection of vintage kolu dolls donated by French photographer and writer Julie Wayne.

"Kolu dolls hold a particularly cherished place within our larger collection of toys and dolls from across South India. These dolls preserve remnants of older and rare doll-making traditions and allow us to share these miniatures with our visitors," says Indu Mohan, the museum's librarian.

Among the figures in the collection are a mother-and-child figurine inspired Raja Ravi Varma, a depiction of Shiva, Parvati and Ganesha seated together as a family, and Vishnu riding Garuda, his celestial eagle, accompanied by his consorts, Sridevi and Bhudevi.

But the dolls tell stories beyond religion and mythology. Miniature wedding and music performance sets owned by 82-year-old Rajeswari Thiagarajan's family, for instance, recreate aspects of social life, while figures of national leaders bring historical personalities into the domestic sphere.

"These days, you don't find such finely defined features or such beautiful faces. Even the miniature sets have perfect finishes," she adds.

The survival of vintage kolu dolls depends not only on the artisans who made them but also on the families who continue to care for them.

Aruna Anand, wife of chess grandmaster Viswanathan Anand, says she enjoys setting out the vintage kolu dolls passed down to her by her mother, Rani Ananth, every year. "These dolls were used by my great-grandmother in our ancestral house in Chittur, Palakkad. My mother inherited some of these dolls, and later, my brother and I inherited them," says Aruna.

Her son, Sai Akhil Anand, an artist, helps her repair the dolls and repaint them minimally. In recent years, the family has stopped buying new kolu dolls every year, choosing instead to focus on the antique pieces they already own.

Soumya Seshan's collection display features antique brass figurines that she believes could be more than 120 years old. Among the highlights are representations of butter Krishna, or vennai thaazhi Kannan and Krishna playing the flute. Also on display is a teakwood cradle once used by her husband's grandfather.

"I use many of these antique vessels for everyday cooking," says Soumya.

Marinating in time

Many youngsters are also interested in vintage dolls, which they now use as decorative pieces in their homes.

Abhinav has his own collection of antique dolls, which he inherited from his great-grandparents. His favourite among them is a standing Krishna.

"These dolls reflect the period in which they were made. For example, a village set depicting a blacksmith, a cobbler and a priest tells us a lot about their clothing and the homes they lived in. I also cherish my kili josiyam and karagattakaran sets," he says.

For public historian and architect Thirupurasundari Sevvel, who is based in Chennai, the significance of these objects lies in what they reveal about the people who made, collected and preserved them.

"A kolu doll can be read as an archive of public imagination," she says, adding "A collection of vintage dolls carefully preserved by a family can, therefore, be seen not merely as an assemblage of objects but as a record of changing public imagination."



Shoppers dont stop Crowds at the LuLu Hypermarket. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Cashing in

LuLu Hypermarket has launched in Shenoy Nagar, and we join a cheery two hour queue

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A trip to the supermarket is rarely an event. It is usually a matter of making a list, navigating the aisles, filling a trolley and joining the checkout queue. At Chennai's newest LuLu Hypermarket inside Shenoy Nagar Metro Station on opening day, the sheer volume of people threatened to overwhelm the act of shopping itself.

Spread across approximately one lakh square feet, the facility is being billed as India's first and largest hypermarket within a metro station. Groceries, fresh produce, daily essentials, fashion, footwear and electronics are available under one roof, with 28 checkout counters, and parking for more than 1,000 vehicles.

The Shenoy Nagar hypermarket is part of LuLu's larger push into Chennai's metro network. The launch also introduces LuLu Daily at Chennai Central Metro Station, a 35,000-square-foot store offering fresh market produce, groceries and everyday essentials.

"Shenoy Nagar is one of Chennai's oldest residential neighbourhoods and it is, in some ways, the heart of the city, so we wanted to be here. This particular hypermart can accommodate approximately 25,000 customers each day," says Abdul Saleem, regional manager.

Part of LuLu's appeal lies in the breadth of its offering. The hypermarket combines everyday purchases with the possibility of browsing for something entirely different.

The fresh food section, however, is perhaps the biggest draw. Fresh produce, meat, seafood and an assortment of cheeses, baked goods and more, give shoppers plenty to browse, even if they have arrived without a specific shopping list. A deli section, a hot kitchen churning out fresh meals, a bakery with bread being baked right in front of the customers, snack section, and even a salad bar gives the customer plenty to choose from.

But the scale of the operation comes with its own challenges. During a visit on opening day, navigating the hypermarket was difficult amid the overwhelming crowds. Some shoppers were standing in queues for as long as two hours at the checkout.

With so much to browse through, taste and take home, many hours of shopping could pass quickly – particularly for those for whom the brand carries a sense of nostalgia. For shoppers familiar with LuLu from Kerala or the Gulf, the visit may have been an opportunity to revisit a familiar retail experience, this time in Chennai.

For everyone else, however, there is little reason to brave the opening-week rush. A visit once the initial excitement settles should make for a far more comfortable experience.

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Your possible pasts

Siennor Trio's *Ninaivu Maaligai* is an 11-track album recorded live, a tribute to the past and a candid look at the Tamil indie scene

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My journey with Siennor's music started by singing 'Innum Enna' (single released in 2021) to a date. The song still flashes memories of a good night, a promise of a beautiful future. Like this romance that once was, Siennor Trio's latest album *Ninaivu Maaligai* (Castle of Memories) looks to respect the past and explores the idea of moving on.

The album, a collection of songs written over the years, besides some new ones, has Siennor on vocals, guitar and keys, Aravind Murali on bass, and Vinay Ramakrishnan on drums. It moves across love, politics, and madness, and blends several genres in one record.

"When I look back at the time when these songs were born, it seems obvious to me that *Ninaivu Maaligai* is a tribute to the things from the past. It wasn't planned really though," says Siennor.

As a producer of the album, Aravind says that he found it interesting musically as it had a lot of different types of movements. "It is fascinating lyrically too. Because it's not like your regular thoughts that have been expressed in Top 40 pop, it ends up having more depth," he adds.

Siennor's early writing was "very simple, and very structured," he says. Then he began breaking the structure. Subsequently, the subject matter changed too. His last album was six songs of introspection: "how I feel on the inside". *Ninaivu Maaligai* turns outwards: "how I feel with somebody else or how I feel on the outside as a part of society," says Siennor.

This album stands out with a blend of rock, sufi, pop, jazz and much more. Unlike other albums that Siennor has written, this one does not really follow a structure either.

"Some songs have an extended outro, some songs have an extended interlude and some songs have no chorus, it's just verse one, interlude, and then verse two," quips Siennor. He gives an example using his new song 'Sambalam Mattum'. "It's completely folk with a Sufi touch to it, like a qawwali where at the end of every verse we come back to the same line, where we can sing together like a chorus."



Aravind's favourite tracks from the album are 'Vaa' and 'Iru Vizhigalile'. Originally written for seven minutes, 'Iru Vizhigalile' comes up to 10 long minutes now.

Holding tight

In the age of Instagram reels and short attention spans, Aravind says bringing out this album is a "leap of faith". He continues, "[This is] kind of rare these days. Hopefully it will stand out in some way. And it's also the way we grew up and listening to our music."

Siennor believes that releasing an album has a lot of space to explore the soundscape of the band. "We have experimented with something. For the next album or next single, we don't have to try the same thing really. A large pressure is off. Now, we can start again." He adds, "Just like the name *Ninaivu Maaligai* goes. Let's pay our tribute to the past. Like a snake shedding its skin. Let's start anew."

Feel of the music

The artistes say that they chose to record the album live with all three playing together in a room, rather than building it on a computer with a metronome. "When we record with a metronome, all of us tend to stay at the same pace throughout the song. That is a very modern recording technique," he says. But after writing, arranging and rehearsing, the songs, even the choice of words, sounded old-school to the band. Playing together meant the tempo would drift. "Since even the way we breathe changes, the rhythm takes a similiar journey. We let it flow. Most of the industry just corrects the mistakes. We just wear them on our sleeves. We want people to feel things," he says.



An outward look (Left) Siennor Trio's new album *Ninaivu Maaligai;* (below) Siennor Trio performing live. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Siennor does not soften it when the talk turns to money. "Live musicians' pay has not been increased in a really long time," he says.

His biggest complaint is about the word indie. Big labels entering the Tamil market is 'fine', he says, but a production with a producer, dancers, and lakhs spent on the video and promotion "doesn't really sound like indie". Once everything sits under one umbrella, he argues, "the weight is going to fall on our shoulders" in terms of the market and business. In his view, much of what is released as indie is just low-budget cinema, he says. While his band has been financially independent, putting in their own money, time, effort, and life experiences," seems essential.

There is some good news. "We're still able to thrive. A little bit," he says. People now buy tickets and turn up for independent music. Yet, the battle persists as mainstream music tends to rule over people's playlists.

I turn to the trio's art to understand these situations better.

A line from 'Sambalam Mattum' says, "*En sambalam mattum yeraliye, yenna nyayam ma?*" (Why has only my salary not gone up? What kind of justice is this?).

As the cruel fates continue to rule the world, I realise that I could not agree more. What really is this kind of justice?

Siennor Trio will be playing live at Museum Theatre on October 17. Tickets are available at outworld.fanpit.live/events/

173 coconuts for Thalaivar

Shri Arulmigu Rajini Kovil near Madurai features a 23-step kolu showcasing stills of actor Rajinikanth

Fan service Karthik performs an arti to the idol. G MOORTHY

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S Karthik, a diehard Rajini fan, is giving the final touches to a life-size foam cut-out of the actor as you read this. The cut-out is a still from upcoming Rajinikanth film *Jailer 2*.

On the day of the film's release, Karthik will be doing milk and curd *abishekam* to it in Shri Arulmigu Rajini Kovil in Thirumangalam near Madurai. He will also be breaking 173 coconuts (equivalent to the number of films he has anchored) as an offering. The cut-out is part of a Rajini-themed kolu Karthik has set up for Navratri.

The temple, that has been in existence since 2023, is Karthik's love letter to his 'thalaivar'. It has a sanctum santorum with a 3.5 ft tall stone statue of the actor in a pose from his iconic 1989 film *Mappillai*. The 49-year-old performs regular poojas, artis, and abishekams to the main idol, even celebrating festivals such as Navratri and Pongal.

This year, he has set up 23 kolu steps featuring 230 stills arranged as foam sheets in the temple. Karthik shifted the temple to a new location in the same town last year, and has pasted as many as 7,500 stills of the actor on the walls and ceiling. He performs evening arti to the Rajini kolu, and has fans visiting every day for dharshan. "Everyone who visits gets a box of sweets and a cup of coffee," says Karthik.

Karthik has come up with some innovative displays for the kolu. This includes a leaf painting of the actor, folded letters from his name that open out into his film stills, among others. "I keep thinking of ways to do something new for thalaivar," says Karthik.

People are welcome to visit the kolu, but Karthik requests them to call him first. He will be busy over the next few days because of the release of *Jailer 2*. For Karthik watches every Rajini release numerous times.

279, Zion Nagar, 2nd Main Street, Thirumangalam, Madurai. Call 8778525269

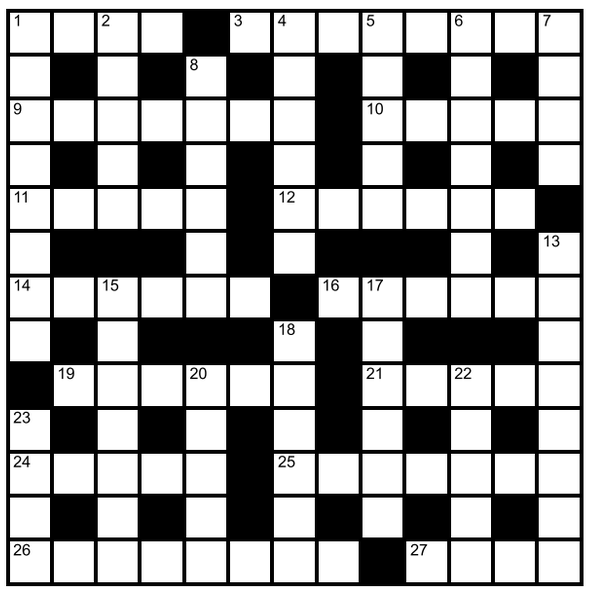


Fashion for sale

Studio Trioss is back in Chennai with its two-day festive edit, celebrating fashion, lifestyle and festive shopping. Featuring designer wear, jewellery, accessories, home décor and more, the exhibition showcases a mix of collections. *@The Folly, Amethyst, Royapettah. October 15, 11am to 8pm. Entry is free. For details, call 9840105010.*

METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #75

(Set by Doppelganger)



To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.

Across

1 Current (4)
3 Edible fat (8)
9 Haven (7)
10 Prize (5)
11 Hooligan (5)
12 Without charge (6)
14 Type of audio (6)
16 Brief promotion (6)
19 All alone (6)
21 Italian dish (5)
24 Relating to pelvic bone (5)
25 Tasteless (7)
26 Login ID (8)
27 Sort (4)

Down

1 Writer (8)
2 Socially inept (5)
4 Not anchored (6)
5 Dessert (5)
6 Satiate (7)
7 Metal (4)
8 Lazy (6)
13 Sit astride (8)
15 Wrap around (7)
17 Remove from office (6)
18 Declare positively (6)
20 Former prisoner (2-3)
22 Lively (5)
23 Instead (4)

Solution No. 75







History speaks (Clockwise from left) Portraits of Charles, Helena and Henrietta Oakeley by Helena Oakeley; Potrait of a Lady 1920; Simon Fonceca's portrait of an officer of the Madras Light Cavalry Regiment (1850). SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Art through time

Explore art that has stood the test of time at Ashvita's Between Tradition and Modernity, an exhibition that sparks conversations about the city's history

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"Thou still unravish'd bride of quietness, Thou foster-child of silence and slow time." It is almost impossible not to recall John Keats's *Ode on a Grecian Urn* as I enter Ashvita's art collection, showcasing art from 19th and 20th-Century Madras. Here, time, with all its charm, is frozen in art that has outlived the artists.

Starting with Tanjore paintings and kolu dolls arranged in one corner, the exhibition ends with a display of analogue photographs from RK Studio. Each piece, a work of art, represents a fragment of time in history.

Layers of history are embedded in Tanjore paintings – a classical South Indian art form that evolved over centuries, with Thanjavur emerging as a thriving creative centre under Nayak rule and Telugu-speaking Raju community artists settling there to become its main creators.

"Later, under Maratha rule, the style truly began to glow," says Rithik Pramod, co-curator of the exhibition Between Tradition and Modernity, adding, "The Marathas blended their love of rich decoration with local traditions, bringing in the refined raised relief (gesso), glass beads, lavish gold foil and gemstones we recognise today."

Despite their rich history, the art forms remain deeply personal. Most paintings depict deities such as a young Krishna and are created on wooden panels, with raised relief work and gold foil. These artworks hang in most Chennai households, where families worship them as their chosen deities.

Colour also acts as a hidden historical language in Tanjore paintings. The extensive use of gold leaf is not merely decorative. It also catches the flickering light of an oil lamp in a dimly lit puja room, lending the paintings a divine glow.

Rithik says the same about kolu dolls displayed in front of Tanjore paintings. "To a foreigner, a doll may be just a painted figure. To a family, it may be a grandmother's gift, standing on the same step every Navratri. So whether a family is protecting a centuries-old Tanjore painting or passing down a traditional kolu doll, they are not just saving an antique. They are keeping faith, regional history and family identity alive in their own living rooms."

Further along, the exhibition explores Chennai's colonial past through portraits by European artists. These mostly include hand sketches of Madras and portrait paintings by George Chinnery from London and John Joseph Fonceca, British-Portugese born in Madras. "The official written records of Madras are full of administrative ledgers and Government decrees. They tell us about the business of the Empire, but very little about what the city actually looked and felt like. Art fills that gap," Rithik says.



Among the European artworks, the portrait of Helena Oakeley particularly stands out. "The painting depicts Helena Oakeley, her family and their domestic staff in their home, surrounded by lush, jungle-like gardens, offering a peek into their life. Their paintings make me feel that documenting Madras through a European perspective was important to them," says Sruthi Srinivasan, co-curator of the exhibition.

Nearby, oil portraits by Indian artists, Bhavani Charan Law, M Pachappa, hang on the walls, capturing members of privileged communities who could afford to commission such works, which serve as documentation of their community, preserving its image for future generations.

Portraiture evolved further with the advent of photography. Subjects no longer had to sit for hours to have their portraits painted. Instead, photographs could be taken, enlarged, retouched with colour, and framed.

Analogue photographs from the 1980s also had a place in the exhibition on tradition and modernity. Drawn from the archives of Malavika Sarukkai and the KR Nathan Studio on Royapettah High Road, they offer a glimpse into the evolution of photography in Chennai.

"Photography is also an art; with the right lighting, right angle, the picture captures and documents the subject," says Rithik.

He adds, "When we preserve these artworks, we are holding onto a blend of everything people have held dear across generations: deep faith, master craftsmanship, artistic knowledge, family traditions, and the legacy of the patrons who kept the art alive."

The exhibition is open from Monday to Friday, 10am to 6pm, at Ashvita's, RK Salai, untill November 22.

We follow the the beat of the dhaak and the aroma of khichuri to celebrate Durga Puja in Chennai. Here is your annual pandal guide



Sounds like home

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In a city where the nine nights of Navratri are marked by kolu dolls, Durga Puja brings a different kind of celebration to the pandals, with the sound of conch shells, the beat of dhaak, sindoor and the aroma of freshly prepared khichuri. For Bengalis living in Chennai and elsewhere away from home, the festival is an emotion that brings a piece of Bengal to them.

From the sight of kash phool swaying in the autumn breeze and the sound of the dhaak to the steaming plates of basonti polao, crisp beguni, kathi rolls, and Kolkata biryani, every little detail brings Bengal closer to home. Add mishti doi, adda with friends and the excitement of dressing up in new clothes for the four days, too. From Saptami to Dashami (October 18 to 21), the celebrations bring together rituals, food and festivities.

The Bengal Association, T Nagar

Tracing its roots to 1929, the Bengal Association has been celebrating Durga Puja since the early 1930s, bringing generations of Bengali families together at its premises on Giri Road, T Nagar. The idol is an ekchala structure (where all deities are housed under a single arch/chalchitra) adorned in traditional saaj (intricate silver foil and embossed ornament work). Visitors can witness the sacred rituals: Pushpanjali, morning prayers, followed by community *maha* bhog (khichuri, labra, and payesh) served during Saptami, Ashtami, and Navami afternoons.

"An important part of our Durga Puja is food donation. We distribute maha bhog free of cost to around 1,000 to 1,500 people every day during the four days of puja. We also distribute clothes at ashrams and orphanages," says Tarun Kumar Das, secretary, Bengal Association, Chennai.

During the four days of puja, in the evenings from 7.30pm onwards, various cultural programmes will be staged in the community auditorium and food stalls serving Kolkata food can be enjoyed by the visitors.

The Bengali Association Durga Puja is celebrated at 29 Giri Road, T Nagar



Hues of tradtion File photos of Durga Puja pandals displayed across the city. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

South Madras Cultural Association, Nandanam

One of the largest in the city, the South Madras Cultural Association (SMCA), which started in Besant Nagar, has now shifted to Nandanam Extension. The puja is said to have been started 48 years ago by a group of Bengalis and non-Bengalis. "For this year we have the theme pandal on Satyajit Ray's Magical Creation, where we are paying homage to him through his films," says Prodyot Bowmick, president, SMCA. Throughout the four days, there will be Gombhira performances (a traditional folk dance) by artistes from Kolkata. On October 19, 9pm onwards there will be dandiya and garba.

The event will feature nearly 50 stalls, offering a taste of Kolkata's street food alongside stalls selling saris, handicrafts and other traditional products.

South Madras Cultural Association's Durga puja is celebrated in Mantra Gardens, Nandanam.

Dakshini Society Welfare Association, Anna Nagar

At Dakshini Society Welfare Association (DSWA), which has organised Durga Puja since 1995, this year's pandal draws on traditional Bengali handicrafts and art forms, including Madhubani and patachitra paintings alongside talpatar pakha (palm-leaf fans), lal gamcha (red towels), kulo (winnowing baskets) and karis. Curated by Nadia-based entrepreneur Anjali Biswas, the decor brings a touch of rural Bengal to Chennai.

"Our cultural programmes are the heart of the puja. They bring together our children, youth, and elders," says Subir Kumar Shaw, president of DSWA. The five-day celebrations will feature two Bengali plays, *Ballavpurer Rajbari* and *Ostader Mar Sesh Rate*, the children's dance drama *Sitaharan Porbo* and the devotional production *Sambahabani Yuge Yuge*.

Food is also central to the festivities, with six stalls serving Bengali specialities and Chinese fare, chaat, ghugni, alur chop, pakoras, lassi, and Bengali sweets.

The 32nd Durga Puja will take place at the BSNL Community Hall, Anna Nagar.

Anya Mukh, Chromepet

For Anya Mukh, a Chennai-based Bengali drama and cultural group that began in 2022, Durga Puja is an opportunity to bring Bengal's artistic traditions and mythology to the city. Now in its third year of organising the festival, the group's theme this year, Sati'r Dehtyag O Shakti Peeth (Sati's sacrifice and the creation of the Shakti Peethas), traces the mythological story of goddess Sati and the origins of the sacred sites across the Indian subcontinent.

The celebrations will feature a Durga idol crafted by Nabadwip-based clay artist Ramesh Pal, with artisans from Krishnanagar creating the thematic decorations and installations. "For us, Durga Puja is not just about the celebrations; it is about bringing people together and creating a home away from home, where we can keep our traditions alive and share them with the wider community," says Atri Kumaar Sinha, president, Anya Mukh.

At Sri Padma Ram Ganesh Mahal, Dr Rajendra Prasad Road, Nehru Nagar, Chromepet

The Dakshin Chennai Prabashi Cultural Association, OMR

The Dakshin Chennai Prabashi Cultural Association (DCPCA) brings together Bengali families and others with a connection to Bengal for its annual Durga Puja celebrations. "We started in 2014, and since then the association has grown from a small group of 20 to 30 people to a community of over 300 members," says Jaypal Menon, secretary, DCPCA. The festivities will feature cultural programmes, including performances by the family of the members across generations. This year the theme celebrates the traditional beauty of *dak er aaaj*, with goddess Durga and her children adorned in white crowns, jewellery, and embellishments handcrafted from natural shola pith. The backdrop draws inspiration from the paintings of Jamini Roy.

Food stalls will include Kolkata-style biryani, varieties of *chops* (cutlets), Kolkata street-style Chinese, chaats, and Bengali sweets.

At Ilara Hotel grounds, Rajiv Gandhi Salai, Navalur.



Unscripted Rehearsals underway for *Slaves*, a new play by Madras Players translated from Tamil to English written by Sujatha. UMESH KUMAR V

A clever act

Ready to see what a collaboration between The Madras Players and writer Sujatha has to offer? Catch *Slaves* a play on fortune, love, and loss

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In a distant corner of the Internet, there exists a review on Wordpress by blogger VishyTheKnight (from 2018) who calls *Sujathavin Nadagangal*, an 830-page collection of Tamil plays by writer Sujatha, absolutely unputdownable.

He summarises everything he enjoys and does not in this detailed blogpost. The first play he lists as his favourite is *Adimaigal* (*Slaves*). He notes that Sujatha, who is most known for sci-fi novels, paints interesting perspectives of his subjects despite choosing dramaturgy, a genre that he is not always known for. Vishy comments, "this play is different, because it is complex, the characters are flawed, and it is impossible to do the good-and-bad binary thing here. Sujatha is clearly breaking new ground here, at least in the Tamil theatre scene (sic)."

Interestingly, during a chat in his Venus Colony apartment, director and vocal artist PC Ramakrishna seems to share similar thoughts about the author's ability to write characters with grey shades. "This is a story about a patriarchal tea estate owner who rules over his nephews with an iron fist. I feel like this is something people might really engage with because it talks about property disputes. What happens to the property when the patriarch falls in love? I enjoy it when people go back with strong opinions after watching a play. I am looking forward to seeing that happen again on October 24," he says, announcing his latest production, *Slaves*, set to be performed by The Madras Players at Narada Gana Sabha.

The cast involves some familiar names who have frequented Chennai's stages and some novices including the likes of Balaji K Moorthy, S Ram, Karthik Sundar, Prasanna Ramachandran, and Anuradha Ramesh.

Ramakrishna says that there has been a steady attempt to build a rapport on stage through rehearsals that have been spanning over two months. This vocal artist whose deep baritone has captured the imagination of several Tamil folks, has been in the theatre space for 60 years now and adds that tweaks at rehearsals are central to building a good production. It is why he invites friends and family over to watch. "It's the feedback at this time that is crucial," he adds.

Ramakrishna says that the inspiration to translate this play and perform it arose because of a conversation between a journalist who had recommended Sujatha as his next author subject.

"I knew him in the capacity of a sci-fi author but not as a playwright. When I was recommended to read *Adimaigal*, I found the process of translation easy because it was already written in the format. This is different from the other plays I have dramatised like [writer] Chudamani's work," he says, adding that the latter was rewritten to fit a play format.

In his long career, PC Ramakrishna has also been responsible for run-away hit productions like *Water*, an English dramatisation of Komal Swaminathan's *Thanneer Thanneer*.

He has also directed Sujatha Vijayaraghavan's *Kamalakshi*, a story about a devadasi dancer. "I am drawn to plays that have strong women characters. It is probably because of the women in my life," he says, adding that his mother, wife, and daughter play a pivotal role in shaping his outlook towards life. "In *Slaves* too, the plot takes a turn because of a woman," he says.

Ramakrishna says that in order to write, one must consistently consume quality work. It is why he reads extensively. "Everytime I read books (he reads multiple at the same time), I'm always thinking about what would make for a good play," he says.

What's next? For now, there is *Slaves*.

Ramakrishna says that the inspiration to translate this play arose because of a conversation between a journalist who had recommended Sujatha

Catch Slaves *at Narada Gana Sabha on October 24, at 6.30pm. Tickets prices start from ₹120. Book tickets at mdnd.in*



Carat and stick

Vimonisha brings L Sunderdas Zaveri to Chennai for the first time with an exclusive jewellery showcase.
Founded in 1901, the family-run jewellery house is renowned for its diamond and gemstone creations, ranging from bridal masterpieces to rare solitaires, blending heritage with contemporary design. *@Hyatt Regency, Teynampet. October 16 and 17, 11am to 8pm. Entry is free. For details, call: 9820043549*



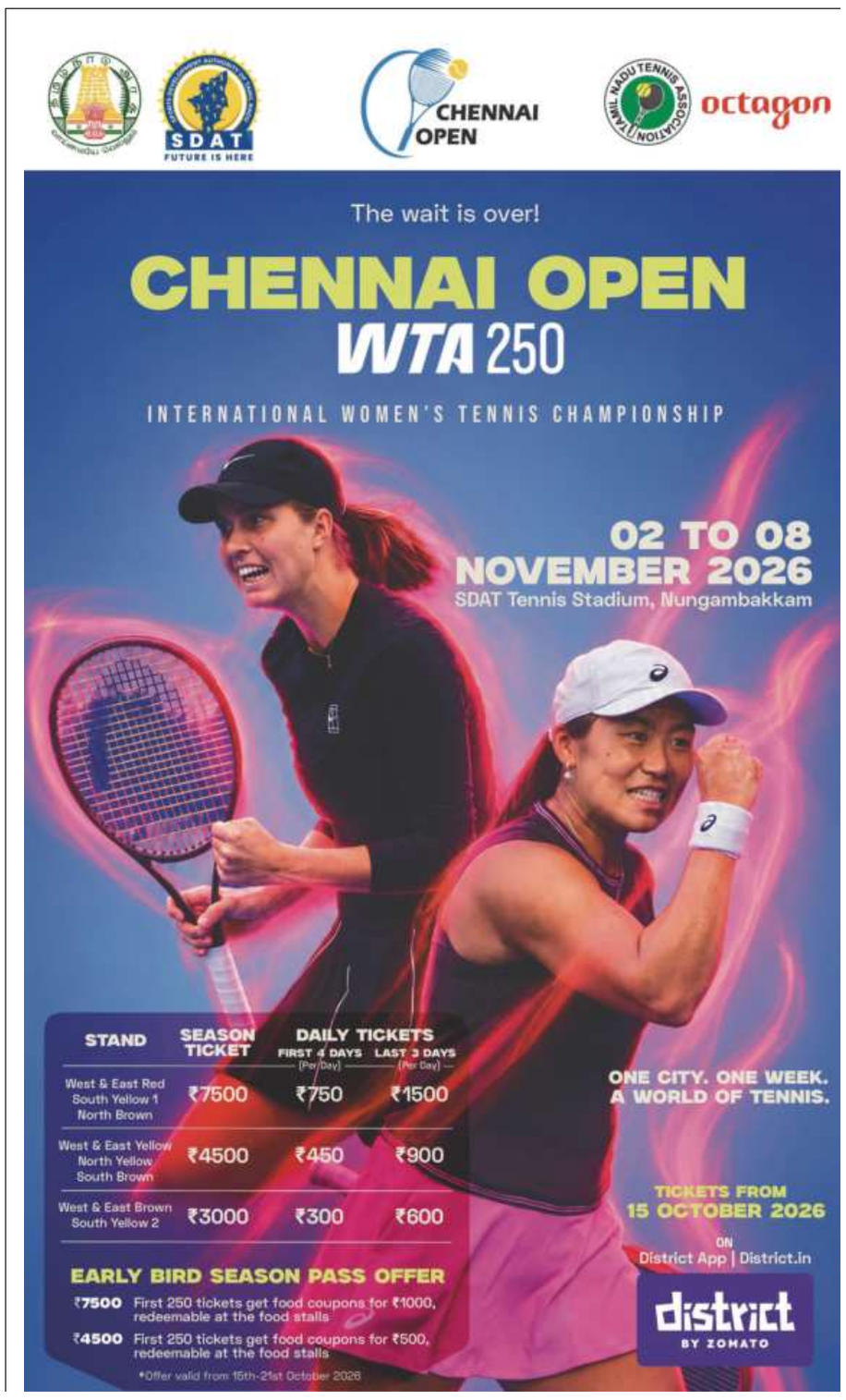
The festive route

Visit Under the Mango Tree, a celebration of music, dance, art and cuisine comes together at My Bungalow till October 16. The festivities feature performances by children and leading musicians, a grand kolu, and a new, expansive and decorative kolam each day. Visitors can also drop by Muttram, a Carnatic canteen offering specially curated menus. *@My Bungalow, Teynampet. Entry is free. Exhibition and canteen from 11am to 8pm and concert from 5pm.*



Tint of tradition

Can Madras checks and traditional weaves find a place in modern lifestyle? From traditional handicrafts reimagined as contemporary home decor to natural beauty products inspired by age-old ingredients, Naar – a social commerce platform – brings together homegrown brands and artisans through Naar Santhai. With the theme nostalgia at heart, Naar Santhai will recreate the 90s charm through products, and interactive activities. Visitors can meet the makers and discover their products in person, while those outside Chennai can join the event live on the Naar app, and shop directly. *Held on October 17 and 18, from 10am to 9pm at Hanu Reddy Residences, Poes Garden. Entry is free.*



TIGER ROARS AGAIN

Even as the Superstar arrives as Tiger Muthuvel Pandian in *Jailer 2*, releasing today, we break down what makes a Rajinikanth film special for fans of cinema

The Superstar effect

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It is that time of the year when theatres in Tamil Nadu turn into festival grounds. It is that time of the year when four generations of Tamil cinema fans flip their sunglasses and flick their hair a certain way. And when the State hopes to see superstar Rajinikanth recreate his magic on the big screen.

The buzz surrounding his upcoming film, *Jailer 2*, ahead of its October 15 release shows that more than 50 years after his debut, Rajinikanth continues to be an industry unto himself, as the highest-grossing Tamil superstar. To the industry, a Rajini film release is the most pivotal day of the year. As producer Kalaipuli S Thanu states, the superstar's films not only support theatre owners, distributors, and producers, but also members of the Film Employees Federation of South India.

"So, the film will impact everyone, from top producers to blue-collar employees. Moreover, his box-office records in Kerala, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and overseas remain undefeated," says Thanu.

This is also why producer G Dhananjheyan says the benchmark the business has set for *Jailer 2* is a whopping ₹1,000 crore.

"Tamil cinema cannot be happy with films doing ₹50, 100 or 300 crores. We need ₹600, 700 and 1,000 crores. And we need a film like *Jailer 2* to do that," says Dhananjheyan, adding that the release window of the film will work in its favour. "It is the holiday season, and there isn't any major competition in Telugu or Hindi. The expectations are high, and the rate at which they sold the Telugu rights is proof."

Jailer 2, in particular, has all the ingredients of a quintessential Rajini blockbuster – to understand why, we need to look at what made the 2023 *Jailer* film so successful. Directed by Nelson, *Jailer* told the story of a retired cop, Tiger Muthuvel Pandian, who is forced to make some calls when his son gets mysteriously kidnapped.

> ***Tamil cinema cannot be happy with films doing ₹50, 100 or 300 crores. We need ₹600, 700 and 1,000 crores. And we need a film like Jailer 2 to do that***
>
> **G DHANANJHEYAN**
> Producer

Jailer, which also featured cameos from Shivarajkumar, Mohanlal, and Jackie Shroff, banked big on the post-pandemic pan-Indian cinema formula to reportedly become the second highest-grossing Tamil movie worldwide.

"The footfalls *Jailer* generated remain unbeatable in most theatres in the State," says Vishnu Kamal, owner, Kamal Theatre, Chennai. "The combination of Rajini sir, Nelson and Anirudh worked well," says Vishnu, while Dhananjheyan credits the film's success to its low-key promotions.

"*Jailer* was an underdog. It wasn't promoted heavily, and nobody expected it to do such numbers." Sun Pictures is following the same strategy now for *Jailer 2*, but don't mistake it for the production house playing safe. According to Thanu, the film is already silently breaking records. "*Jailer 2* has been sold at a much higher rate than his films usually are. It has already done more business than *Jailer 1*. That is enough proof for what is to come," says Thanu.

Like its predecessor, *Jailer 2* too features a star-studded ensemble; apart from starring Shivarajkumar, Mohanlal, Mithun Chakraborty, and Jackie Shroff, it also features Suraj Venjaramoodu, SJ Suryah, Vidya Balan, and Ramya Krishnan.

Interestingly, this also marks one of the few sequels that the superstar has made in his long career. This is another cause for excitement, says Vishnu.

"As he stated at the pre-release event of *Jailer 2*, he does not do sequels usually – he avoided sequels for *Baashha* and *Petta* – but if he is doing *Jailer 2*, I believe the content must be quite good."

As a theatre owner, Vishnu is confident that the film will attract families to theatres. "Among the top stars, Rajini sir and Vijay sir (former actor and Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu) have huge family audiences. And because Rajini sir's previous film *Coolie* was an A-Certificate film, children could not come to theatres, and so it didn't become a family outing."

In more than half a century of Tamil cinema history, if there is one star who has consistently taken the business of Tamil cinema to new heights, it has to be Rajinikanth, and in a year like 2026 – when only a handful of big-ticket films have been released – Rajini becomes a mantra.

Now, all eyes are on October 15 to see whether the Superstar of Tamil cinema recreates his magic once again. As the lyric goes, '*Innaikum endrendraikkum oru thalaivan dhaan.*' (Now and forever, there is only one leader)



> ***A Rajinikanth release will have an impact on everyone in the film industry, from top producers to blue-collar employees***
>
> **KALAIPULI THANU**
> Producer



Time for action
Action director Chethan D' Souza with Rajinikanth. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

How Rajini fights

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Action director Chethan D' Souza is tight-lipped about Rajinikanth's upcoming film *Jailer 2*. But the excitement of being part of one of his career's biggest projects is apparent, as he opens up about the chain of events that led him to *Jailer 2*, directed by Nelson.

Having made an impression in the Kannada film industry (*Bhageera*, *Max*, *Ghost*) for more than a decade, Chethan aimed to take his career to the next level. That is when the Fahadh Faasil-starrer *Aavesham* (2024) arrived as the perfect platform for him. "It was the success of *Aavesham* that landed me *Jailer 2*," he tells us, "Nelson sir saw that and asked me to execute the stunts of the promo of *Jailer 2*."

Chethan says Nelson was impressed with the blend of action and humour in *Aavesham*. "He has a similar approach to action. The characters retain their unique traits even during the action scenes. The set pieces had a quirky, manic energy, perhaps making them different from what we had seen before."

Pulling off the action set piece for the first promo of *Jailer 2*, which featured Nelson, music composer Anirudh, and Rajinikanth, was like passing a litmus test for Chethan. A bigger achievement was breaking the ice with the 'superstar' himself, says Chethan. "Initially, I was hesitant to talk much with Rajini sir. Usually, I speak in Kannada with my team. He heard me speak Kannada and asked if I was from Karnataka. I told him, 'Yes, I am from Mangalore.' He was very happy to hear that, and continued talking to me in Kannada. He asked me about my journey, parents, and so on. I can never forget that meeting."

The action director was fascinated by how Rajinikanth naturally blends style with action. "What's surprising is that Rajini sir knows exactly what we want. For instance, when we plan a stylish moment with a prop, we tell Rajini sir the kind of impact we want from the scene. When he does the shot, he brings something of his own, often surpassing our expectations. That's what experience can do."

Revisiting *Jailer* helped Chethan study the film's visual style and the character staging. Though the film served as a template to choreograph action scenes for the sequel, delivering what Nelson wanted was far from easy for the Bengaluru-based action director.

"My school of action involved plenty of camera movements. But in Nelson's set pieces, the camera is static. It was challenging for me because when the camera is static, you need to be perfect with your movements. It's hard to hide your small slip-ups," he explains.

As an artiste, Rajinikanth was an open book, often ready for suggestions, recollects Chethan. What inspired him more was the superstar's humility. "If you are egoistic about being a successful artiste who has delivered back-to-back hits, then you will be humbled by just being in his vicinity. He doesn't have bouncers around him. Be it anybody, he will stand up and talk to them. He will make sure you are an equal."



A new page

It is well known that Tamil filmmaker Thiagarajan Kumararaja has reunited with his *Super Deluxe* star Vijay Sethupathi for an upcoming film titled *Pocket Novel*. The film, currently in production, was set to have music composed by maestro Ilaiyaraaja. However, it is now known that the legendary composer has opted out of the project.

A source close to the production has confirmed to *The Hindu* that Ilaiyaraaja has exited the project and that GV Prakash Kumar has been roped in as the music composer.

Pocket Novel, also starring Kannada star Raj B Shetty, Kishore and Malavika Mohanan, marks Kumararaja's return to feature film direction after seven years.

With a story and screenplay written by Andrew Louis (*Leelai*, *Kolaigaaran*, *Vadhandhi: The Mystery of Mani*), the upcoming film has cinematography by Nirav Shah and editing by Sathyaraj Natarajan.

Forgotten past

With *Ranabaali*, Vijay Deverakonda takes a closer look at what happened during the Great Madras Famine

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Period take
Vijay Deverakonda and Rashmika Mandanna. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

In the Telugu period drama *Ranabaali*, releasing on October 16, Vijay Deverakonda plays Singanamalla Bobbili Ranabaali, a fictional chieftain inspired by the legends of three palegars from the Rayalaseema region. Directed by Rahul Sankrityan and set during the Great Madras Famine of 1876-78, the film is also Vijay's first project with Rashmika Mandanna since their wedding early this year.

When he sits down for an interview at a studio in Hyderabad, Vijay reveals that when Rahul pitched the story of *Ranabaali*, he had incidentally been hooked on to *Empire*, the podcast by Anita Anand and William Dalrymple.

"I was deeply moved, enraged, and also wondered how we do not know enough about the consequences of the British East India Company exercising political control over our country. I remember reading about the Battle of Plassey in school, but the focus was on memorising dates of key battles rather than understanding how these battles shaped our history."

Ranabaali takes a closer look at what happened during the famine. "Different accounts state that we have lost several lakhs of people; our natural wealth and food were plundered," says Vijay.

The film's team released a four-episode short video series, *Never Forget*, explaining the history and the film's context.

Vijay describes how Rahul pored over gazettes and books across Mysuru, Ballari, Chennai and Coimbatore. "We hope this film sparks conversations about the period," says Vijay, whose character is an amalgamation of three palegars. "The story begins and ends with my character, and we look at the famine, the British officers and their policies."

The Rayalaseema flavour

Vijay asserts that the film's biggest strength is Rahul, who hails from the Rayalaseema region. The film's promos offer glimpses into the folk art form burra katha, through which stories of chieftains are narrated. References also came from *Braveheart* for his characterisation.

Dressed in handwoven whites throughout the film, Vijay says the attempt has been to keep the portrayals and milieu as authentic as possible.

"A lot of research went into the ornamentation, architecture and depiction of people in the region. We took a few liberties," he says, and explains how instead of showing women sporting oiled hair and blouses that reach their wrists, the look of the women was tweaked to a later period.

"Right from how the men twirl their moustache, everything was planned. Rahul kept asking for retakes when I couldn't spit water like a fountain. Finally, I asked him to show it," he says with a laugh.

This is the first time Vijay is shedding his urban image. "A film and a character like this require maturity, both physically and as an actor. I was ready when this film came my way. I am confident that we will be able to transport the audience to that world. And, Rahul has named Rashmika's character after his mother, Jayamma."

The wedding photo

Ranabaali brings Vijay and Rashmika together after *Geetha Govindam* (2018) and *Dear Comrade* (2019). The first day they shot together for *Ranabaali* was for the now-famous wedding photograph scene.

Vijay recalls, "We were already engaged then. She walked in dressed like a bride. I was preoccupied on set, but couldn't help appreciating how beautiful she looked. Rahul showed us an old photograph and wanted us to recreate that look. It looked authentic. It captured the era, and the mood of the couple who did not know each other before marriage."

Working with Rashmika post marriage, Vijay says, has been quite different from working with her on *Dear Comrade*. "She has this ability to switch off from work once we are home, while I keep thinking and speaking about cinema. She reminds me to disconnect and have a life."